Late polling surge boosts Democratic odds in Senate

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【メール原文】

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Blockbuster Kansas poll highlights downside risk for Democrats
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Expect Trump to claim Iran deal is close this weekend

Late polling surge boosts Democrats’ odds in Senate. Democrats have had a very good week in Senate polling. Accordingly, we’re moving up our odds that Democrats will flip the chamber to 65% (from 60%).

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Two sets of high-quality polls this week have both pointed to an exceptionally good night for Democrats on Tuesday.

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Yesterday’s tranche of CNN polls had Democrats up by 6 in Texas, 4 in Maine, 7 in Michigan, and 4 in Kansas. Along with North Carolina, a near-certainty to flip, those would give Democrats a 51-seat majority.
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New York Times/Siena College polls earlier this week pointed to a tied race in South Carolina, deep in Republican territory, and a Minnesota racing leaning solidly Democratic (see Times/Siena poll points to a good night for Democrats , 28 October 2026).

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Two things appear to be happening at once in the final days of the campaign, both good for Democrats: They are shoring up their “blue wall” states of Michigan, Minnesota, and New Hampshire, all of which had looked somewhat shaky despite Democrats’ national strength; and they are holding onto leads at least six Republican-held seats, depending on the polling average, of which they need four to win a Senate majority.

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Even with the possibility of a 2024-style polling bias, overstating Democrats by about three points on average, Democrats' leads are large enough that they would win 51 seats. If polls on average perform as they did in the last two midterm cycles, the margin will be much more comfortable.

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Meanwhile, Republicans are getting no relief on the macro front. Democrats' lead in the generic ballot remains around nine points; a recent Republican recovery in vote share (from 40.7% to 42.4%) has been almost entirely offset by a surge for Democrats as well, up to 51.2%. President Donald Trump's approval rating isn't improving either, remaining in the 37% range. Both of these drag down Republicans across the country.

High Black turnout would be a problem for Republicans in the South. Early voting numbers in the South are going bonanzas, with the total number of ballots cast early in a number of states easily surpassing figures from the 2022 midterm. About 750,000 ballots have been cast in South Carolina, up from a total of 561,000 in 2022; in Louisiana, early-voting numbers are up 40% from the previous midterm. Georgia has also already broken records.

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At least in Louisiana, there is real evidence that this surge has been driven by Black voters; the state is reporting that Black voters cast about one-third of early ballots, up from about one-quarter in 2022. South Carolina Democrats are reporting slightly lower, but still impressive figures.

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Early voting analysis more an art than a science, and it's not clear that this early turnout advantage for Black voters—who are overwhelmingly Democratic—will carry into election day; it's possible that early turnout is "cannibalizing" election day turnout.

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There is reason to think that Black turnout particularly in the South will be much higher than usual in a midterm cycle, driven by the community's organization following the Supreme Court ruling that in effect allowed Southern states to eliminate a number of Black-held House seats. If early-voting numbers are indeed an indication of high Black turnout into election day, that would be unalloyed good news for Democrats, making a South Carolina win very plausible and even potentially bringing Louisiana into the realm of competitive states.

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Black turnout in the South, particularly in early-reporting Florida, will be one of the key signals to watch on election night; turnout running well above the 2022 baseline would be a positive signpost for Democrats.

Blockbuster Kansas poll highlights downside risk for Democrats. Democrat Adam Hamilton led Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS) by ten points in today's Washington Post poll of Kansas, an almost-too-good-to-be-true number that highlights how the polling could miss this year.

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This poll is a major outlier; Democrats do appear to lead in Kansas, but not by much, and no poll except for the Washington Post one so far has shown Democrats with more than a four-point edge.

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To its credit, the Post was transparent about the methodological issues it faced in polling Kansas. In particular, Republicans just didn't appear to be picking up the phone; around 30% of polled Democrats

completed the survey, compared to just over 10% of Republicans and around 10% of independents. That the problem appears to be far more pronounced in deep-red Kansas than in other states the Post has polled, namely Maine and Michigan, suggests it could also be polluting polls in similarly Republican states like Texas or Iowa.

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This is where polling could go wrong for Democrats. If Democratic enthusiasm is sky-high this year—especially in deep-red territory where Democrats haven't been competitive is years—while Republican enthusiasm has plummeted, Democrats may be responding differentially in a manner for which pollsters, despite their best efforts, just can't correct. The possibility of that dynamic is a key driver of our view that Republicans have a real shot at holding their Senate majority (35% odds).

Expect Trump to claim Iran deal is close this weekend. With oil flows reduced from prior pre-war highs but above March lows, oil prices above $110 per barrel, and the midterm elections approaching, clients should expect Trump to announce a deal with Iran is imminent this weekend.

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An announcement would reprise a recurrent Trump playbook: announcing a deal over the weekend to drive prices lower and improve domestic political dynamics. As seen in September, clients should view such an announcement skeptically; prior announcements in this pattern have not delivered durable outcomes.

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Tehran has little incentive to give Trump a pre-election gift. The structural drivers reinforcing the current standoff – the US naval blockade on Iran, continued Iranian strikes in the Strait of Hormuz, and the unresolved question of nuclear enrichment – remain firmly in place with narrow space for a potential deal.

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The more meaningful watchpoint remains whether the US will escalate, militarily, after the midterms, which we continue to place at 65% odds.

Quote of the Day

"Trump's diesel deal with Putin is corrupt and illegal, and I am evaluating options to stop it [a Russian tanker] from arriving at a port in New Jersey." - New Jersey Governor Mikie Sherrill speaking to the Financial Times. Three tankers with Russian diesel are scheduled to arrive in the US after the midterms; it is unclear what legal authorities Sherrill has to stop them, though one route could be challenging the Trump administration's sanction waivers in court on the basis that they conflict with a 2022 law banning the import of Russian oil or distillates. While the diesel deal is the product of a low point in US-Ukraine relations, we expect the partnership to slowly be rebuilt and view a further US shift towards Russia as unlikely (please see Diplomatic fallout with Ukraine will persist beyond intelligence-sharing resumption , 23 October 2026).

On the Radar

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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